

Stromboli

A small volcanic island, known for thousands of years as the Lighthouse of the Mediterranean because of the regularity, reliability, and brilliance of its eruptions



Stromboli is one of the few places on Earth that anyone can visit, on any day, with a high likelihood of being able to witness a volcanic eruption. Around every 20 minutes, one of its three summit vents blasts a fountain of lava fragments up to a height of 490 ft (150 m). These eruptions have been occurring for several thousand years and are so distinctive that geologists use the term Strombolian to describe similar eruptive activity at other volcanoes.

Visiting Stromboli

Roughly 3 miles (5 km) in diameter and 3,032 ft (924 m) high, Stromboli lies north of Sicily in the Mediterranean. A hike to the summit is permitted only in the company of a local guide. The eruptions can also be viewed from a boat off the island's northwest coast.

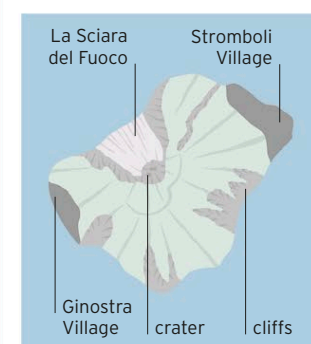
▷ GIANT FIREWORK

This photograph shows a typical eruption at Stromboli. Hundreds of glowing lava particles blast into the air, then fall to the ground in gentle arcs.



VOLCANIC ISLAND

Steep paths from two shoreline villages lead to vantage points for viewing eruptions. During forcible explosions, streams of lava cascade down a depression on one side of the volcano called La Sciara del Fuoco.



The Urals

An upland divide between Europe and Asia and one of the most ancient and mineral-rich mountain ranges on Earth



The Ural Mountains are about 1,600 miles (2,500 km) long and run north to south, from the Arctic Ocean to near the Aral Sea, encompassing a wide range of landscapes, from polar wasteland to semidesert. Located in Russia and Kazakhstan, they have traditionally been regarded as a boundary between Europe and Asia.

Ancient mountains

Partly due to the long period of erosion since they were formed, the Urals are not exceptionally high. The highest peak is Mount Narodnaya, with an altitude of 6,217 ft (1,895 m). Much of the area is forested, although the northern Urals are strewn with glaciers and also

feature alpine meadows and tundra. An extensive network of rivers and lakes covers the region, while karst topography, with many caves, is found on the western slopes. This mix makes the Urals one of the most beautiful areas in Russia. The richest and most varied fauna in the Urals are found in the forests and include brown bear, lynx, and wolverine. The mountains are particularly rich in natural resources, including lumber, coal, metal ores, and a range of gemstones.



◁ CRYSTALLINE TREASURE

Amethysts, emeralds, and topaz are among the precious gemstones mined in the Urals. This uncut hexagonal crystal is an emerald.

The Urals formed **300-250 million** years ago and are among the **world's oldest mountains**

